

Governance of the LAs Community

Francisco Pando

GBIF Spain / CSIC



TDWG Annual Conference - A hybrid
conference in Oslo, Norway, 21-25
September

Living Atlases around ALA: From Deployment to
Contribution and Future Technical Directions

20 September. Møterom 115 - Lids Hus
Naturhistorisk Museum, Oslo



Objectives: What we want to get out of this session

Put all of us on the same page

- Clarity
 - Why we are here
 - Who we are
 - What we want
 - What are our commitments
 - How are we going to work
 - Communicate
 - Cooperate
 - (Among ourselves, with ALA)
- A governance structure
 - Lightweight
 - Sustainable
 - Membership eligibility criteria
 - A sustainable coordination mechanism, financially and otherwise

Notice: this is a straw-man

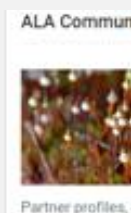
The beginnings

What is all about

“The Atlas of Living Australia (ALA) is probably one of the more advanced bioenvironmental portals in the world and is unique in having interfaces that appeal to audiences ranging from primary school education to citizen scientist to postgraduate research”

Lee Belbin & Kristen J Williams

<http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/13658816.2015.1077962>



“ I want one, can I have one?”

2013: GBIF's Mentoring project

Atlas of Living Australia (ALA) and
GBIF – Costa Rica



John La Salle --ALA

María Mora -INBio



2015. The heat is on:

- “Atlas of Living Europe Meeting”
- In association with the “GBIF European Nodes Meeting”
- “Encounter Bay”: translations, documentation , led by Belgium
- Sharing infrastructure : e.g. Andorra-Spain
- More countries interested





Regional Engagement Workshop, BID Caribbean
June 23rd, 2017

Living Atlases community

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2017 / 2018

CESP Project :

- CESP Regional event between 13 nodes to organize the 1-week workshop in 2018 in Madrid (advanced level).
- CESP Mentoring between Canadensys and GBIF France to help open the community to French-speaking countries.
- CESP Mentoring between GBIF Benin and GBIF France to install the Beninese data portal based on ALA

TDWG 2017 :

- Beginner workshop around Atlas of Living Australia tools (between one day and half a day – duration to be confirmed)

Collaboration

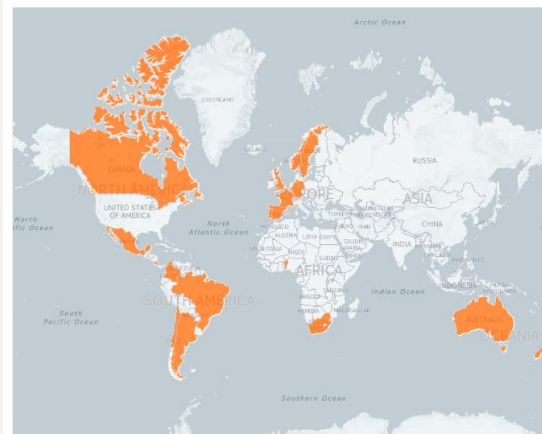
- GBIF Argentina has begin to help to install ALA in Colombia.
- GBIF Spain has begin to work on the installation of the ALA portal in GBIF Andorra.

2017 / 2018

INTERREG SUDOE Project

- BIOGLASER: collaboration between GBIF Andorra, GBIF France, GBIF Spain, GBIF Portugal and other institutions to create a biogeographic Living Atlas based on ALA modules for a better management of the biodiversity in the SUDOE area.

Countries involved



<https://living-atlases.gbif.org/assets/presentation/BID/12-ALA-community.pdf>

The constitution of the Living Atlases Community



- 2018: The Kilkenny Accord -
Strawman Living Atlas
Community of Practice
 - https://docs.google.com/document/d/14tyjEPaDplo9B_8wvHDKbfMRLO81FviTsVQt9IT1I1o/edit?usp=sharing
 - Clear objectives
 - Clear commitment
 - Clear framework

GBIF announcement, October 2019

Strengthening the Living Atlases Community of Practice

The GBIF Secretariat has funded two half-time positions in the network to assist in developing a growing community of practice around 'Living Atlases'.

Published October 14th, 2019 by Marie-Elise Lecoq

The constitution of the Living Atlases Community: Activity



Living Atlases

The open community around the Atlas of Living Australia platform

Home Participants Resources News Projects **Events** Contact About ▾

Name	Funding	Lead	Year	Type
From shared experiences to shared knowledge and common solutions: collaborating to improve web-based tools in Latin America and the Caribbean	GBIF & co-founders	GBIF Brazil	2020	Workshop
International Living Atlases workshop - how to improve data use with Atlas of Living Australia modules	GBIF & co-founders	GBIF France	2018	Workshop
Workshops on usage of the Atlas of Living Australia (ALA) and GBIF.org data portals	GBIF & co-founders	Canadensys	2018	Documentation
Francophone mentoring and translation of the open-source ALA platform	GBIF & co-founders	GBIF France	2017	Workshop
Internationalization of the ALA node portal	GBIF & co-founders	GBIF Belgium	2015	Documentation
CoopBioPlat	European Union	GBIF Spain	2015	Meeting & Workshop

Name	Type	Date	Status
TDWG 2026 workshop WKS50: 'Living Atlases around ALA: From Deployment to Contribution and Future Technical Directions'	Workshop	2026-09-20	Upcoming
Living Data 2025 session: 'How Living Atlases and Nodes Support Regional Environment Policy and Decision Making'	Conference	2025-10-21 to 2025-10-24	Finished
ALA-LAs Technical Workshop (Madrid, March 2025)	Workshop	2025-03-11 to 2025-03-14	Finished
SBDI-LA developer workshop in Gothenburg Sweden (2022)	Workshop	2022-06-09 to 2022-06-10	Finished
TDWG Virtual Conference 2020	Online Conference	2020-10-19 to 2020-10-23	Finished

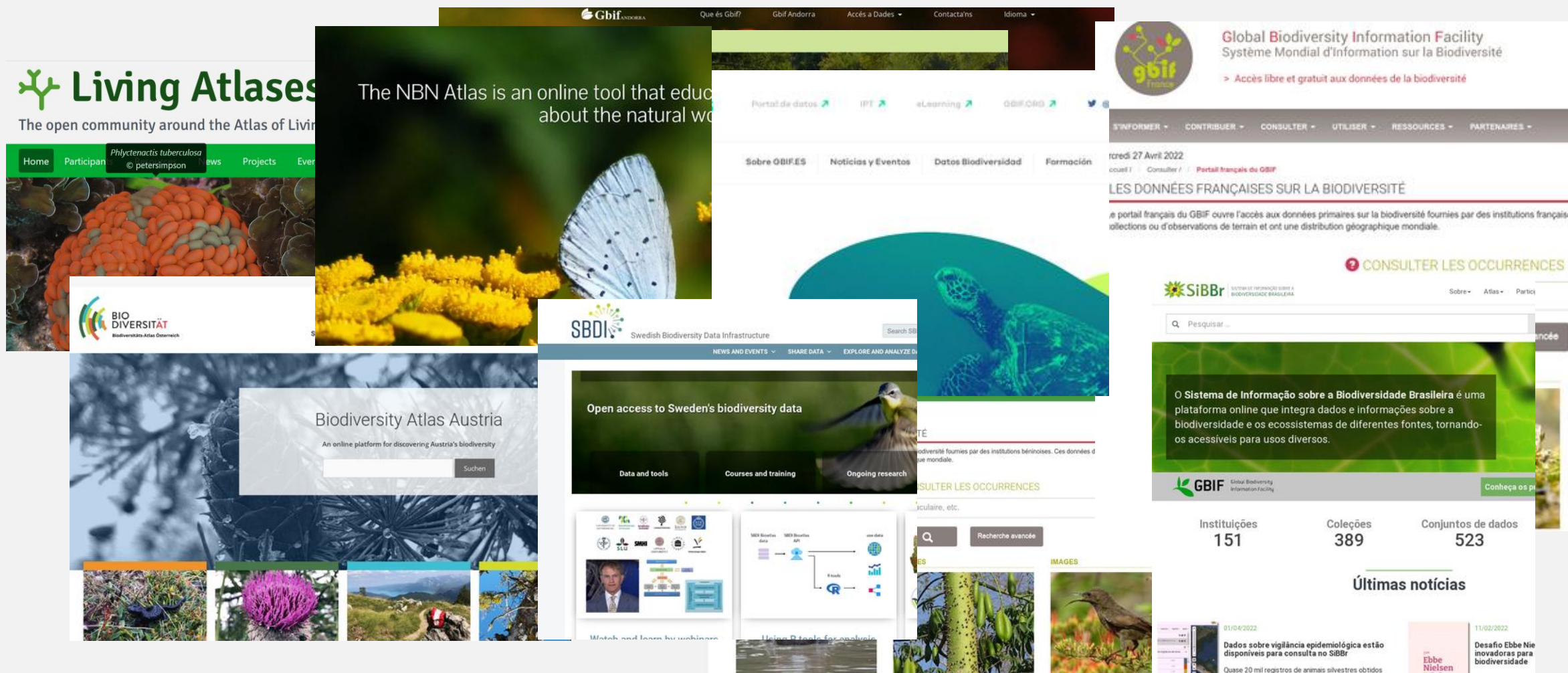
<https://living-atlases.gbif.org/>

Latest landmarks

- Madrid Workshop
 - <https://gbif.es/talleres/ala-las-technical-workshop-madrid-march-2025/>
- Interactions with ALA in a coordinated way:
 - Letter exchange
 - Meeting at Living data (Bogotá 2025)
- Outcome:
 - An agreed communication and coordination procedure:
 - Contact persons
 - Regular exchanges

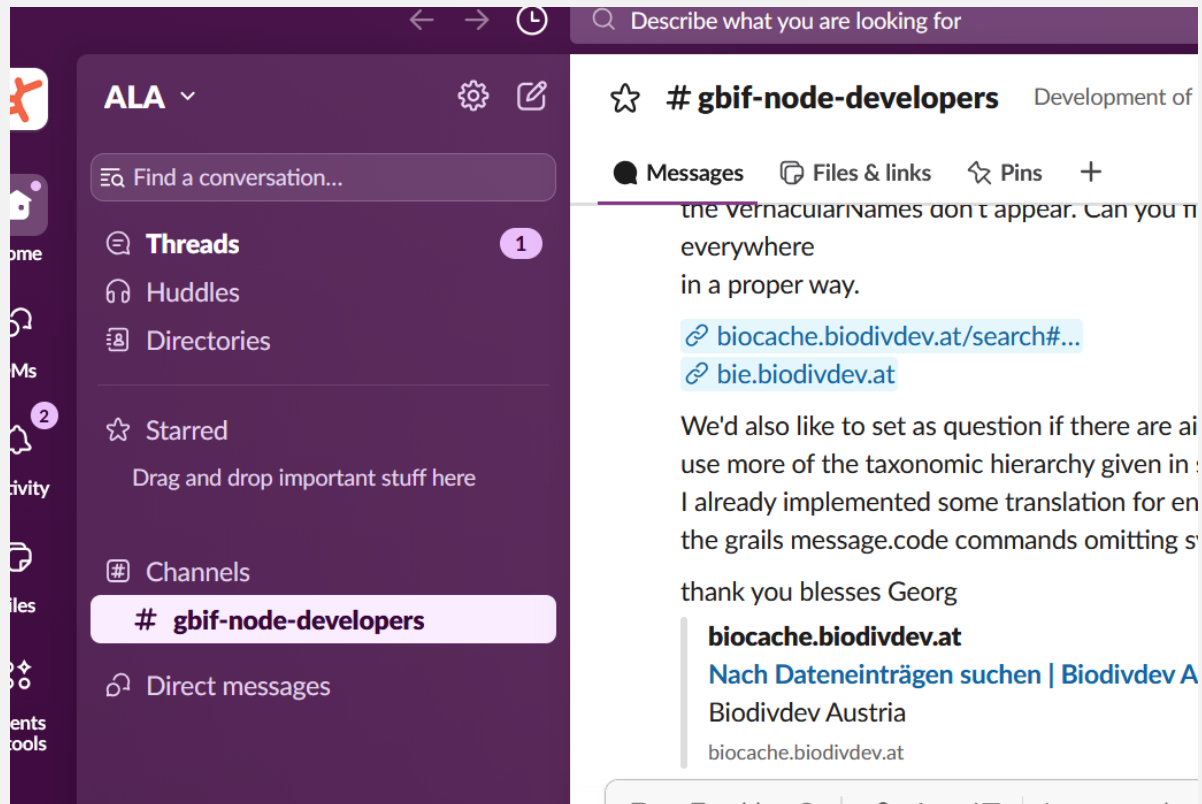
Current situation

- A global community of ALA-based portals up and running



Current situation

- Technical communication works:
- Slack channel
- A way to work together, but being not the same



ALA vs LA builds

One dish, two ways to cook it

One kitchen: the same shared repositories

**ALA build**
Builds and deploys exactly as today.

**LA build**
A generic build, with condiments added at the table by each portal.

Nothing changes for ALA. We only need a little help from ALA to review and approve the changes that permit this way of working.

The draft we want to agree on

Next-gen guidelines: seven ideas

 Settings Per portal, without rebuilding	 Look & feel Your logo, colours, banner	 Languages Add or fix one without rebuilding	 Under the hood Swappable parts, like login
 Data start-up A repeatable first set-up	 Packages Public, with version numbers	 Runs anywhere Not tied to one cloud	 Your turn Open draft: read, edit, comment

Each idea becomes a question in the Reusability Test. [Open the draft](#)

Current situation

- Community is fragile
 - Local requirements weight heavily; each partner suffering in its own particular way
 - Heterogeneity
- Same things done by different teams
- Work wasted because incompatibility with new ALA versions
- Communication is irregular

What we need, what we can do

- Make collaboration efficient
- Good follow-up of decisions, commitments, actions
 - We are good at planning, not so good at walking the talk
- A clear commitment/return of investment framework

Points for discussion

- Resources for community management:
 - A community manager
- A membership framework: who we are, why we are who we are
 - Expected benefits
 - Expected commitments

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